HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Beyond Bitahon? The Four Levels of Trust & Total Entrustment

Given Monday 20 July 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 8.8

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem — Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam (Rav Dana's Hebrew edition) **Chapter:** 8 — Bitachon and Reliance (conclusion) **Topic:** The highest levels of bitachon — Level 3 (certainty) and Level 4 (hafkadah, total entrustment) — bitachon in the final redemption, and a summary of the entire chapter

Schedule note: The final shiur before the summer break — completing Chapter 8 after some seven or eight weeks in it, the longest chapter of the sefer. We restart b'ezrat Hashem toward the end of August (Rosh Hashanah is very early this year, so timing to be confirmed).

Recap — The Levels So Far

Not bitachon at all (from last week): (a) one who has given up hope — despair; (b) one who puts his trust in another person or thing instead of Hashem. Those are simply *lack* of bitachon.

Among those who do trust Hashem, there are **four levels** — and Rabbi Avraham will say this evening that he is not entirely sure all four fall under the *word* "bitachon"; the word itself shifts meaning by context.

Level	Description
1	Trusts Hashem — but with doubts: "do I deserve it? Perhaps Hashem won't give it to me"
2	Trusts (perhaps still with doubts) — **and also turns to Hashem**: prays, seeks Him, wants the relationship

Rabbi Avraham: the vast majority of us are obligated in **at least level 1 or 2** — that is the bare minimum; below that is not bitachon at all.

Part 1: Level 3 — Certainty Without Doubt (חוסה בה׳)

1.1 The definition

המדרגה השלישית היא מעלת מי שבטוח בהשגת משאלותיו מאתו יתעלה, מאמין בזאת בוודאות בלי ספקות

One who trusts that his request will be fulfilled — **with certainty, without any doubts**. No "perhaps, perhaps not": I trust in Hashem and I *know* it will happen as I trust.

וזה נקרא חוסה בה', מאמין בו, בוטח בו — this is "taking refuge" in Hashem: completely under His wing, and certain.

The models:

- **Avraham: והאמין בה' ויחשבה לו צדקה** — when promised children and the Land, he trusted fully, and Hashem accounted it worthy.
- **Our ancestors in Egypt: ויאמן העם וישמעו כי פקד ה'** — the very first time Moshe and Aharon spoke to them, the people believed fully.
- **The counter-example — the generation of the midbar: ודור המדבר יצא מן הכלל מפני שחסרו מעלה זו** — as it says, **בדבר הזה אינכם מאמינים בה' אלהיכם ההולך לפניכם בדרך**; and Assaf in Tehillim: **לא האמינו לדברו ולא חכו לעצתו** — not only did they not trust, they would not even take the advice (they still didn't listen to the two spies).

1.2 Who can reach it? Only through nevuah or Ruach HaKodesh

מעלת הבטחון זו לא ישיגו רוב בני אדם

Most people cannot attain it — because how can you be *certain* Hashem will grant what you seek? (And remember: bitachon is not always about what I *want* — it is about what I need in order to do Hashem's work. Even when you are convinced something is best for your avodah, you cannot be certain it will happen.) Certainty is possible only through **prophecy or Ruach HaKodesh** — or by being told by someone who has experienced them:

- **Avraham** could be certain — **כשבישרו ה' על דבר הבנים** — because he was *told* in prophetic revelation.
- **The generation leaving Egypt** — **ויאמן העם** — note: the people did *not* hear from Hashem directly; they were told by **the messenger of Hashem** (Moshe) through nevuah — and trusting a verified navi is itself obligatory (below).
- On this level David said: **ויושיעם כי חסו בו; בך חסיתי; ביי חסיתי איך תאמרו לנפשי...**

1.3 Important: the word "bitachon" is context-dependent

ולפעמים יבוא ביטוי בטיחה in different senses — it can denote **levels 1, 2 or 3** depending on context, since all three are bitachon, albeit different levels. Sometimes "boteach" describes one who trusts with doubts; sometimes the seeker; sometimes total certainty.

(The Rabbi asked mid-shiur for someone to check how often the shoresh בטח appears across Tanach — the answer came back: around 120 times, roughly half in Tehillim, matching his estimate of ~100+ with 50–60 in Tehillim. His summer suggestion: whenever you read a bitachon pasuk, ask which level it is describing in context.)

1.4 The prophets' praise — and the restriction

This is the loftiest level of bitachon (level 4 may not be "bitachon" at all — below), and the Nevi'im praise it greatly:

והבוטח בה' חסד יסובבנו · בוטח בה' אשריו · ה' צבאות אשרי אדם בוטח בך

But — unlike levels 1 and 2, which bind **every** shomer Torah in all his ways:

ואילו מעלה זו לא תיכון אלא במי שהוא חף מן העוונות ונקי מפשעים והגיע לשלמות וטעם מהשגחתו יתעלה

Level 3 befits only one clean of sin who has reached perfection and *tasted* Hashem's hashgacha. David captures both tiers in one verse: **ויבטחו בך יודעי שמך כי לא עזבת דורשיך ה'** — "those who **know Your name**" (prophecy/Ruach HaKodesh — level 3) will trust in You; "You do not forsake **those who seek You**" — the seekers (level 2). And the complete, faithful **seeking is the prerequisite** — the necessary preface — to reaching level 3.

1.5 Chanina ben Dosa — the fluency test

The famous Mishnah in Berachot: R' Chanina ben Dosa would pray for the sick and know the outcome. They asked how:

אם שגורה תפלתי בפי — יודע אני שהוא מקובל; ואם לאו — יודע אני שהוא מטורף

"If my prayer is fluent in my mouth, I know it is accepted; if not, I know it is rejected." *(This is the same R' Chanina who lived למעלה מן הטבע — the vinegar-that-burned-like-oil story, and the snake story we saw earlier in the chapter.)* At times he had exactly this level of certainty.

And crucially — it is not arrogance:

אין זה מפאת בטחונם מצדקתם וזכותם, אלא מפאת בטחונם בחסדו יתעלה — כמו שאמר דוד: ואני בחסדך בטחתי יגל לבי בישועתך

The certainty flows not from "I am so righteous that Hashem must answer me," but from closeness — from trust in His *chesed*: I know this is what is best, what is needed for Am Yisrael and the world, and therefore He will grant it.

1.6 Being told by a navi — a Torah obligation of certainty

כל דבר שבא ממנו יתעלה על ידי נביא נאמן — חייב כל מאמין להיות בטוח בהשגתו ללא שום ספק

Even without your own prophetic experience: once a prophet has been **verified** (recall the machloket Rishonim on verification — Saadia leaning on miracles; the Rambam on the navi's qualities plus predictions that come true), you are *obligated* to accept his word with full certainty.

This is why the anger went out against Bnei Yisrael at Masa u-Meriva: they had seen what they had seen — **כי עין בעין נראה אתה ה' וענך עומד עליהם** — and had been told by the navi that Hashem would lead them through the desert; yet they cast doubts and tested the hashgacha — **היש ה' בקרבנו אם אין**. Hence — in **this week's parsha, Va'etchanan**:

לא תנסו את ה' אלהיכם כאשר ניסיתם במסה

Do not test Hashem as you tested Him at Masa — i.e., once a navi's prophecy is verified, you must believe and hold it true. As the Rambam codifies at the end of **Yesodei HaTorah (ch. 10)**: a navi may be verified directly or by another navi's testimony; and a navi known as such —

אסור לחשב אחריו ולומר שמא נבואתו אינה אמת... ואסור לנסותו יותר מדאי... אלא מאחר שנודע שזה נביא — יאמינו וידעו שה' בקרבם, ולא יבחנו ולא ינסו אותו

It is a prohibition — one of the 613 — to second-guess or keep testing a verified navi.

Nowadays: we have no nevuah (as the Gemara says, and as the Rambam discusses in the Moreh), so this route to level 3 is largely inapplicable — **חייבים אנחנו כל שומעי התורה** to hold at least levels 1 and 2; level 3 binds **whenever it genuinely comes to us from Hashem**.

1.7 בטחו בה' עדי עד — two readings

בטחו בה' עדי עד כי בי-ה ה' צור עולמים

Rabbi Avraham: the verse depends on which level "bitachon" means here.

1. If **level 3** (commanded through prophecy): *adei ad* = trust **completely, absolutely**.
2. If **levels 1–2**: complete certainty is impossible (you don't *know* it will happen) — so *adei ad* = trust in Hashem **in all matters, for everything**. Support from the verse's ending: **כי בי-ה ה' צור עולמים** — Hashem is the **Rock** of the worlds *(and what "Tzur" means is exactly one of tomorrow evening's Moreh chapters — this very verse comes up there!)* — **שהשם יתעלה מייסד כל העולמות** — He founds and sustains all; everything one could lean on — wealth, property, standing — traces back to Him; therefore lean on Him in everything, **ואסור להישען בזולתו שהוא פעול ולא פועל, מסובב ולא סיבה** — never on what is caused rather than the Cause, subject to change, suffering and death: **אל תבטחו בנדיבים בבן אדם שאין לו תשועה... תצא רוחו ישוב לאדמתו... אשרי שאל יעקב בעזרו שברו על ה' אלהיו**.

1.8 Bitachon and the final redemption — which level?

Timely for this week — shavua shechal bo, our minds on Tisha B'Av, the Beit HaMikdash, the Sanhedrin, the geulah. Work it through the levels:

- **Level 1 — trust it will come?** Certainly. Giving up hope on the geulah is a failure of emunah in the fundamentals.
- **Level 2 — seek it, pray for it, want it, try to bring it?** Certainly — three times daily in the Amidah.
- **Level 3 — full confidence it will happen in my lifetime? No.**

מוטל עלינו כל שומרי תורת משה רבנו... שנאמין בגאולה הנכספת

We are obligated to believe in the awaited redemption — Hashem told us in His sefer: **ושב ה' אלהיך את שבותך ורחמך... ושב וקבצך מכל העמים אשר הפיצך ה' אלהיך שמה** *(aside: Menasseh Ben Israel — founder of the Spanish & Portuguese community here in England, 1656 — took "from all the peoples" so literally that he held Mashiach could not come while England banned Jews, which drove his campaign for readmission; probably not the pshat, but a wonderful historical note)*; and in Haazinu: **כי ידין ה' עמו ועל עבדיו יתנחם...**; and the Nevi'im are full of it beyond counting.

And note the model of the Avot: Hashem told **Avraham** at the Brit Bein HaBetarim — **וגם את הגוי אשר יעבדו דן אנכי ואחרי כן יצאו ברכוש גדול** — but we never find Him telling Yaakov or Yosef directly. Yet **Yaakov**: **הנה אנכי מת והיה אלהים עמכם והשיב אתכם אל ארץ אבותיכם**; and **Yosef**: **פקד יפקד אלהים אתכם והעליתם את עצמותי מזה אתכם**. They believed the prophecy though not told explicitly — all the more so us.

But as to one's own lifetime:

אך אם יבטח כל אחד מאתנו כי יקום הדבר ויהיה בחייו כפי דרגת הבטחון השלישית — אין זה בטחוננו כפי המעלה השלישית. כי אפשר שיקום הדבר בזכותו ורחמיו יתעלה, ואפשר שלא יקום מפני חטאינו. ולפיכך נאמר: אשרי המחכה ויגיע — כי לא כל המחכה יגיע

It may come in our days — it could be today, b'ezrat Hashem, it could be Thursday, it could be a hundred or two hundred years — we cannot be *certain* we will see it; "fortunate is the one who

waits **and arrives**, for not everyone who waits arrives." We hold levels 1 and 2, we pray, and we hope to be among the fortunate.

1.9 Ruach HaKodesh — level 3 without full prophecy

ומלבד זאת אולי תהיה לאחד מאתנו a divinely-granted intuition: **מגודל חסידותו וחסדו יתבונן בו כח הרגשה זו, ומתוך כח הרגשה זו יבטח בדבר ההוא כפי המעלה השלישית — אף על פי שלא באה לו ההתגלות הנבואית ממש**

A person of great piety may be given a powerful sense — strong divine intuition — and on its strength trust with certainty, though no actual prophecy occurred. **Hillel HaZaken** (Gemara Berachot):

מעשה בהלל הזקן שהיה בא בדרך ושמע קול צווחה בעיר, אמר: מובטח אני שאין זו בתוך ביתי. ועליו הכתוב אומר: משמועה רעה לא ייירא נכון לבו בטוח בה'

Hearing screams in the city, he said "I am certain this is not from my house." Not prophecy — intuition at the level of Ruach HaKodesh; and that too sits within level 3.

Part 2: Level 4 — הפקדה: Total Entrustment (perhaps beyond bitachon)

2.1 The definition

המדרגה הרביעית היא מעלת ההפקדה. ופירושה — שיפקיד האדם את ענייניו או אחד מהם בידי השם יתעלה ויסיר מעליו כל צפייה ותשוקה, עד שאם לא ישיג דבר שהשתוקק עליו — יסתפק... ונמצא מסתפק במה שגוזר ועושה השם יתעלה

A person deposits his affairs — all of them, or even one of them — into Hashem's hands and **removes all expectation and desire**. Whether or not he attains anything makes no difference to him; he is content with whatever Hashem decrees and does.

The contrast with level 3: level 3 is still *about something* — "I have full confidence I will receive X" (even the navi: full confidence Hashem will grant him life to speak His word). Level 4 says: whatever happens to me — I have no want; it is all in Hashem's hands; there is nothing left to seek.

2.2 Is it even bitachon?

זאת המעלה, אם אפשר למנותה ממעלות הבטחון — היא העליונה שבכולן; ואם אין למנותה ביניהן — הרי היא עליונה וקדושה למעלה מכולן

If it counts among the levels of bitachon — it is the highest; if not — it is a holy level *above* them all. Why the doubt? Because bitachon, as defined all these weeks, is trust in Hashem **for something you want**. Here there is no want. It may simply be a different — higher — category.

2.3 The sources — and the Rabbi's honest difficulties

(a) Beshalach — התיצבו וראו את ישועת ה': trapped against the sea, Moshe says "stand and see the salvation of Hashem..." Rabbi Avraham reads a hint to hafkadah here. **The Rabbi's difficulty:** *yeshuah* implies waiting to be *saved* — which is precisely a want; on level 4, whether

I live or die is equally accepted, so "salvation" seems to cut against entrustment. The footnote suggests the weight is on **התיצבו** — stand *firm*, whatever happens. And a lovely connection: **tomorrow evening's Moreh includes the word נצב** — which can denote firmness/permanence — so perhaps: *stand firm, permanently — and whatever comes is the yeshuat Hashem*, because you have wholly entrusted yourself. (The Rabbi: "I find it difficult; if anyone reads it another way, I'd be happy to hear.")

(b) The anger over the water in the midbar — **ויש בזה רמז לחיוב הבטחון כפי מעלה זאת** — Rabbi Avraham calls it a *hint* that they were expected to reach entrustment. (The Rabbi: note the tension — a few lines earlier the same episode illustrated the failure of *level 3*; how he derives an expectation of *hafkadah* here is not clear. **אלו הם הרמזים** — they are, as he says, hints.)

(c) Explicit — Eliezer eved Avraham:

> **הנה אנכי נצב על עין המים ובנות אנשי העיר יוצאות לשאוב... היא האשה אשר הוכיח ה' לבן אדוני**

(That word נצב again!) Eliezer sets the test and hands the outcome entirely to Hashem — **כלומר הפקיד את הדבר בידי השם יתעלה**: whatever Hashem chooses and desires as beneficial — "that is what I have intended and decided." Not up to me anymore.

(d) David — מסירת העניין בידו יתעלה: cast your burden on Hashem — **השלך על ה' יהבך והוא יכלכלך** — and He will sustain you as His good wisdom decrees. (The Rabbi again playing honest devil's advocate: *v'hu yechalkelecha* — "He will sustain you" — names a want, sustenance; arguable.)

(e) The strongest textual case — גול על ה' דרכך ובטח עליו והוא יעשה: roll your way onto Hashem, trust in Him, *and He will do*. Rabbi Avraham himself spells out the two readings of **והוא יעשה**:

1. He will do **His will** (**כפי מה שעלה רצון מלפניו**) — a pure level-4 verse: heap everything on Him; whatever He does is good.
2. He will do **your will** — then it belongs with levels 1–3.

And he offers a beautiful composite reading: if you cannot reach the hafkadah of **גול על ה' דרכך** — then at least hold fast to the bitachon of **ובטח עליו והוא יעשה**. Compare **ויבטחו בך יודעי שמך / כי לא עזבת דורשיך** — one verse spanning distinct levels.

2.4 The levels are contiguous — and we move between them

> **כי כל מדרגות הבטחון ראויות לשבח... ואפשר שההדמות ביניהן לפי שהן רצופות. כי בעל הבטחון יש לו בעת... המעלה הראשונה שקראתיה תקוה, ויש לו... מעלת ההפקדה**

The levels shade into one another, and one person moves among them: sometimes in tikvah (trusting while fearing), sometimes — in certain matters — in complete entrustment. **The Rabbi's sharp observation:** we usually arrive at level 4 only when there is *no alternative* — "there is nothing more any human can do; I hand it all to Hashem." Rabbi Avraham is teaching us to come to hafkadah **even when there is an alternative**.

2.5 The explicit exemplars

David (Shmuel, as he flees Yerushalayim):

אם אמצא חן בעיני ה' והשיבני והראני אתו ואת נוהו; ואם כה יאמר לא חפצתי בך — הנני, יעשה לי כאשר טוב בעיניו

"If I find favour — He will bring me back and show me [the Aron] and His abode; and if He says 'I do not want you' — here I am; let Him do to me as is good in His eyes." Brings me back — great; doesn't — also great. Explicit hafkadah.

Chananya, Mishael and Azarya (Daniel), before the furnace:

> **הן איתי אלהנא די אנחנא פלחין יכיל לשיזבותנא... והן לא — ידיע להוא לך מלכא די לאלהיך לא איתנא פלחין**

"Our God whom we serve can save us — **and if not**, know, O king, that we will not serve your gods." We do not know whether we will be saved; either way, whatever happens is right — and we serve Him regardless.

2.6 Rabbi Avraham's closing words on the chapter

> **ועכשיו איני מטיל ספק שכבר נתתי לפרק זה ביאור מספיק... וה' יתן לנו — הוא אשר מאתו נבקש עזר — בתיקון מצפוננו הפנימיות והחיצוניות כפי שנאמר בחיבור זה**

"I have now given this chapter sufficient explanation." And the fitting end: after seven or eight weeks of intellectual study, the work is implementation — and *that* is sought from Hashem Himself: may He grant us help in repairing our inner and outer conscience as set out in this work.

Part 3: Summary of the Whole of Chapter 8

Part 1 — The definition. Bitachon is complete reliance on Hashem, Creator of all, to whom everything in the universe is subservient. Living with it produces *betichah* — security and serenity. One does not place trust in the intermediaries Hashem created — medicine, wealthy patrons, any person or means.

Part 2 — The three TYPES (not levels) of bitachon.

1. The bitachon of the **prophets**, who divested themselves of natural means **by Hashem's instruction** (Eliyahu and the ravens).
2. **Denial** of Hashem's providence — Aristotle's world running on self-sufficient natural law — including the **hidden deniers** who outwardly affirm bitachon but deep down don't. *(The Rabbi's challenge: examine ourselves honestly — do we say "I trust in Hashem" and then chase this person, that connection, that doctor, without the framework we've learned?)*
3. The **correct** bitachon of the majority: Hashem oversees all the regular intermediaries He set in the world — real causes with real effects — and can change their regular operation whenever He wills. We engage the natural world (unlike the prophets, who had explicit instruction not to need it); we neither go overboard in pursuit of goals nor become lazy relying on miracles (the chachamim had jobs; relying on miracles is arrogance).

Part 3 — Cause and effect. No contradiction between bitachon and natural causality. Not the **Mutakallimun**, who abolished cause and effect to "protect" providence (against experience — and mocked by scientists); not **Aristotle**, whose causes run immutably once created. The correct view: real cause and effect, under Hashem's constant oversight, changeable at His will.

Part 4 — The five categories of employing bitachon (× physical/spiritual = ten):

1. **Avoiding serious harm** (mortal illness, a storm at sea): employ every natural means, pray (Tehillim 91 — יושב בסתר עליון — the Rabbi's recommended psalm for strengthening trust), and remember the outcome is Hashem's; when nothing remains but bitachon, sometimes one is saved and sometimes not — that is His hashgacha. (Including the discussion of enemies.)
2. **Minor harms:** Rabbi Avraham's chidush — do **not** employ bitachon (the wasp bothering you); other Rishonim disagree — trust Hashem even in the smallest things.
3. **Essentials** (basic food, clothing, shelter): trust and do everything reasonably possible — with the two questions (why is bitachon needed if Hashem feeds all creatures? and is trust natural — עיני כל אליך ישברו — or praiseworthy?) and their answers.
4. **Important non-essentials:** for yourself, essentials suffice; for wife, children and dependents — bitachon even for the non-essential; and for some (arguably all of us nowadays) the non-essential is effectively essential.
5. **Luxuries:** wrong to employ bitachon — "make me win the lottery" — who said you may ask for that?

Part 5 — The four levels (tonight): (1) trust with doubt; (2) trust plus seeking and prayer; (3) full certainty — only via nevuah, a verified navi, or Ruach HaKodesh; (4) **hafkadah** — entrustment: whatever Hashem does is good. For the **redemption**: levels 1 and 2 — always; level 3 — impossible regarding one's own lifetime (**אשרי המחכה ויגיע**).

Coming Up

Tomorrow (Tuesday) — the final Moreh shiur of the season: three chapters including **Nitzav** and **Tzur** — both of which surfaced tonight (Eliezer's אנכי נצב; בטחו בה'... כי בי-ה ה' צור עולמים is quoted by the Rambam there). Then the **summer break** — restarting b'ezrat Hashem toward the end of August (Rosh Hashanah is early this year).

B'Ezrat Hashem

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